

Building a KDP Book Cover in Canva

Paperback and hardcover wrap covers, from cover calculator to print ready PDF

Amazon KDP does not accept separate front and back cover files. It requires a **single PDF** containing the back cover, spine and front cover as one continuous wrap. This guide covers that build end to end.

1. Get your template from the KDP cover calculator

Go to `kdp.amazon.com/cover-calculator` and enter:

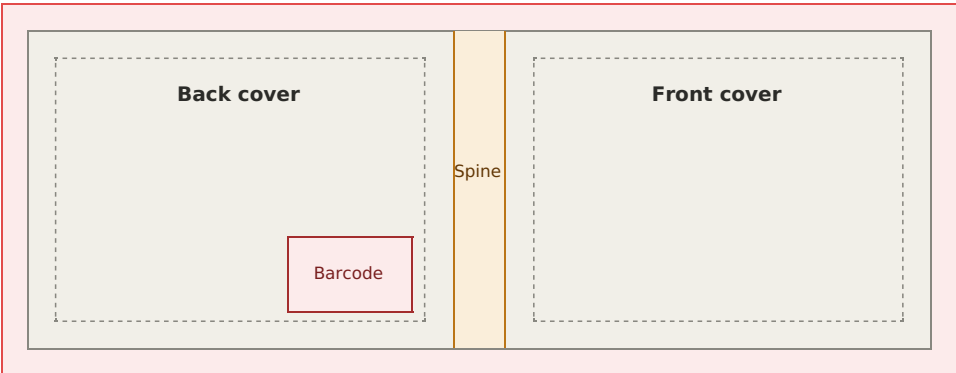
- Binding type (paperback, or hardcover case laminate)
- Interior type (black and white, standard colour, premium colour)
- Paper type (white, cream, colour)
- Page turn direction
- **Final page count**, exact, not an estimate
- Trim size and measurement unit

Click **Calculate dimensions**, then **Download template**. You receive a ZIP containing a PNG and a PDF version of the template. Note the full cover dimensions it reports. A 6 x 9 in paperback at 200 pages on white paper comes out at roughly **12.700 x 9.250 in**. Write that number down, you will need it twice.

Lock the interior first. If the page count changes by even one page, the spine width changes and the entire cover has to be rebuilt to new dimensions.

2. Understand the zones you cannot touch

The template you downloaded marks four restricted areas. This is the anatomy of a wrap cover:



Outer pink band: bleed, 0.125 in, trimmed off. Dashed rectangles: safe zones. Amber strip: spine. Lower right box on the back cover: barcode reserve.

The four rules that get covers rejected

Zone	Rule
Bleed	Background art must run right to the outer edge of the canvas, but the outer 0.125 in on all four sides is trimmed off. No text, faces or logos there.
Safe zone	Keep all text and important imagery at least 0.25 in inside the trim line, which is 0.375 in from the outer canvas edge. Trimming drifts by up to 0.125 in on a print run.
Barcode reserve	KDP prints a barcode on the lower right of the back cover, roughly 2 in wide by 1.2 in tall. Leave a plain, light, unbusy area there or the barcode will not scan.
Spine	Spine text is permitted only at 100 pages or more. Keep text at least 0.0625 in inside each spine fold and centre it. Below roughly 130 pages, use the title only or leave the spine blank.

Hardcover adds two more. The template includes a wrap area of about 0.6 in on all four sides that folds over the board and is never seen, plus a hinge strip on each side of the spine. Nothing important goes in either, and the background must fill the entire wrap area with no white edges.

3. Set up the Canva canvas

1. In Canva, click **Create a design**, then **Custom size**.

2. Change the unit dropdown from px to **in**.
3. Enter the exact full cover dimensions from the calculator, for example width **12.700** , height **9.250** .

Set the size in inches, not pixels. Inches tell Canva the physical dimensions, so the PDF Print export comes out at 300 DPI automatically. If you set the canvas in pixels, the PDF carries the wrong physical page size and KDP rejects the file.

4. Load the template as a guide layer

1. Open the **Uploads** panel and upload the PNG template from the ZIP.
2. Drag it onto the canvas and stretch it to fill exactly, corner to corner.
3. Select it, click the three dots, then **Lock**. Optionally set Transparency to about 40 percent so you can see through it.

The PNG is now your tracing guide. It shows the spine folds, trim lines and barcode box exactly where they belong.

5. Build the three panels

Work back to front so the layering stays clean.

1. **Background first.** Place your background image or colour block and stretch it edge to edge across the whole canvas, covering the bleed. One continuous background across back, spine and front reads as far more professional than three separate blocks.
2. **Front cover.** Title, subtitle and author name, all inside the right hand safe zone. Keep the title in the upper third so it stays legible at thumbnail size on the Amazon listing.
3. **Spine.** Add a text box, type the title, then use **Position** and rotate 90 degrees, or use the rotate handle while holding Shift. Centre it inside the spine strip and zoom to 200 percent to confirm it does not touch either fold line.
4. **Back cover.** Blurb, author bio and imprint logo, all inside the left hand safe zone and clear of the barcode box. If your background is dark, place a plain white or light rounded rectangle over the barcode area so the printed barcode has clean contrast.
5. **Alignment.** Canva's **Position, Align to page** centres on the whole canvas, not on one panel, so front cover elements must be positioned by eye against the template guide.

6. Pre export checks

- Zoom to 100 percent and walk the perimeter. Any element with a hard edge inside the bleed band gets cut.
- Confirm no text crosses a spine fold.
- Confirm the barcode area is clear and light.
- **Delete or hide the template PNG.** This is the single most common mistake. Leave it on and the pink and blue guide lines print on the finished book.
- Replace any Canva Pro element you have not paid for, otherwise the export carries a watermark.

7. Export to PDF

1. **Share**, then **Download**.
2. File type: **PDF Print**.
3. **Leave "Crop marks and bleed" unchecked.** Your bleed is already built into the canvas size. Ticking this adds a second bleed on top and produces an oversized file that KDP rejects.
4. Tick **Flatten PDF**. This removes transparency, which KDP does not accept.
5. Colour profile: CMYK if you have Canva Pro, otherwise RGB is accepted.
6. Download.

8. Verify before uploading

Open the PDF and check **File, Properties, Page Size**. It must match the calculator dimensions to within about 0.01 in.

What you see	What went wrong
12.95 x 9.50 in instead of 12.70 x 9.25	Crop marks and bleed was left ticked on export
Something like 4.23 x 3.08 in	Canvas was built in pixels instead of inches
Pink and blue lines visible	Template PNG was not deleted before export
Faint diagonal watermark	An unpaid Canva Pro element is still on the canvas

Upload the file in KDP as your **complete cover**, not the front cover only option. Always open the **Previewer** and step

through it. The previewer draws the real trim lines on your file and is the last chance to catch a title sitting too close to an edge.

Quick reference

Measurement	Value
Bleed, all four sides	0.125 in
Safe margin, from trim line	0.25 in
Safe margin, from canvas edge	0.375 in
Barcode reserve	2 x 1.2 in, lower right of back cover
Spine text clearance, each fold	0.0625 in
Minimum pages for spine text	100
Full cover width	(2 x trim width) + spine width + 0.25 in
Full cover height	trim height + 0.25 in
Export resolution	300 DPI, set the canvas in inches

Pegasus Press house rules still apply on top of this process: photorealistic imagery only, no icons, badges, vector or clip art, no selling point callouts on the cover, no violence or blood, and no background base colour repeated within a five cover window.